‘sorrow and regret’. Again, Beijing protested US actions, accusing it of straying into Chinese airspace and attacking its fighter plane.

At the same time, US economic engagement, public and private, with China dramatically increased. When trade and copyright tensions between the two countries escalated, Washington proposed that in return for Chinese compliance with international trading and intellectual property norms, it would support China’s membership in the World Trade Organization (WTO). A trade deal with Beijing in 1999 led to China’s eventual membership in the WTO in December 2001. At the private level, US investment firms led by Goldman Sachs advised Beijing on how US investors could help fund financially strapped Chinese state-owned enterprises (SOEs). It was not just economic engagement. After the Al Qaeda attacks in the US, China was the first country to phone President Bush and express its sympathy and support. Beijing went on to vote for the UN resolution authorizing the use of force in Afghanistan. When the extent of the North Korean nuclear programme became clear, Bush asked for and got Chinese help to bring Pyongyang to the negotiating table.

Even as US–China relations oscillated between conflict and cooperation, Beijing and Moscow drew closer. In 2001, they signed a Treaty of Good-Neighbourliness and Friendly Cooperation and increasingly supported each other on global issues. With a group of Central Asian republics, they also formed the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) that year. In 2004, they settled their disputes in the eastern part of their borderlands. Economic interactions grew dramatically. Bilateral trade in 2001 was nearly $11 billion but by 2008 had grown to $57 billion.[32] When Russia was hit by a financial crisis in 2008, Moscow turned to Beijing for loans. China’s energy imports from Russia’s far east became a major element of their relationship. The Chinese military bought Russian defence equipment to the tune of $2 billion per year from 1999 to 2005, consisting largely of naval equipment and the Su-30 aircraft. They agreed on co-production, licensed production in China, and joint R&D. Two thousand Russian scientists worked in Chinese defence establishments. They exchanged military personnel,